

Critically assess the views expressed in the Mulieris Dignitatem

The Mulieris Dignitatem is a letter issued by Pope John Paul II which illustrates the core values of the Catholic Church on gender roles in society. Its title translates to "On the Dignity and Vocation of Women", mirroring its overall message which highlights the equal dignity of men and women while expressing the innate differences in the way that this dignity is upheld through their vocations. On this basis, this essay will argue that the views expressed in the letter fail to resolve the patriarchal gender roles embedded within Catholicism due to the emphasis the Pope placed on women's dignity being tied to their motherhood, as well as the separation between the roles of men and women, as these views compromise the equality of the female sex and are thus inherently discriminatory.

Primarily, the status of Mary as the feminine ideal is central to the Mulieris Dignitatem. Paul cites Mary as the "greatest figure" among women due to her unique role as the Theotokos - mother of God, which has given her the highest honour possible for a human. This status has direct implications on the role of women as a whole. Mary's motherhood reflects the honourable vocation of woman as being tied to their unique capacity to nurture the gift of life. In this way, motherhood represents a spiritual participation in the act of creation that is both their vocation and their dignity.

However, this reverence of women's status as mothers is what shapes the discriminatory aspect of the letter, as it ties the value of a woman to her capacity to engage in a purely biological function which often restricts their freedom and autonomy. Simone de Beauvoir, for instance, criticised what she called the "cult of motherhood" which attempts to justify the restriction of women's opportunities through the false romanticisation of a biological function. She asserted that this is a thinly veiled mechanism of the patriarchy; if women are reduced to their reproductive functions then they become alienated from their identity as individuals and enslaved by their dependence on men. Thus, the inherent value placed on motherhood in the Mulieris Dignitatem could be viewed as problematic as it upholds a patriarchal system that limits their autonomy by imposing a supposedly noble destiny on them without considering personal choices, limiting their access to equal opportunity.

In spite of this criticism, the Pope may have argued that this analysis fails to recognise the unique dignity asserted by motherhood. He upheld the equal dignity of the sexes in this letter, asserting that the fact that all humans were created in the likeness of God gives them a fundamental dignity regardless of gender. However, the vocation of women as mothers is nothing more than

an expression of this dignity which men cannot gain access to. If anything, it could be argued that women are especially close to God as they participate in his creative power in a way that men never can.

This argument is ultimately unconvincing, however, as it continues to tie women to an oppressive model of dependence and inequality. Regardless of the supposed spiritual gift of motherhood, in practice biological determinism has led to the dehumanisation of women and their restriction to the private sphere of society in a commitment to the nurturing of a child throughout its life. Shulamith Firestone insisted that women must be separated from reproductive processes in order to be truly liberated for this very reason. Therefore, the *Mulieris Dignitatem* expresses a view on motherhood which is damaging to female equality, as parenthood should not be connected to gender identity or else it risks imposing an oppressive essentialist view on women and compromising their autonomy.

Another aspect of the *Mulieris Dignitatem* which can be read as problematic is its distinction between the roles of men and women in society. While asserting the equal dignity of the sexes, Paul upholds their different, yet complementary, roles in society. He insists that sexual differences are a part of God's will, and that this difference does not necessarily imply inequality, as men and women play mutually supportive roles to one another.

For many feminists, this concrete separation between the two sexes is not only arbitrary but also harmful as it legitimises inequality and forces women to accept an inferior role in society. Judith Butler expressed the idea of gender performativity - gender is not an innate, biological concept, but rather a social performance expressed subconsciously due to learned behaviour. For this reason, gender roles are not pre-ordained and can be subverted, allowing men and women alike to reclaim control over their identity contrary to the views of the Pope.

However, the Pope's position could be defended on the basis that while biological sex is a cause of female oppression, true liberation must not ignore its fundamental existence and the crucial part it plays in determining behaviour and shaping societal roles. Mary Daly, for example, defends biological determinism to some extent, arguing that sexual difference should be embraced as the reality of it is obvious and cannot be truly erased. For instance, uniquely female experiences like menstruation are not performances but things that shape women's realities. So, instead be celebrated and valued in order to truly lead to female empowerment, and it could be argued that the Pope is simply a realist in his observation and application of the differences between sexes.

Nonetheless, even when celebrating the female biology, applying these differences to societal roles is fundamentally dangerous as it plays into oppressive pseudo-science. Once more, Simone de Beauvoir would argue that biology cannot construct a woman's destiny: an ability to menstruate does not make women nurturing, or naturally suited to care-giving roles. The 'maternal instinct' is simply a product of social conditioning. Therefore, distinct social roles do not necessarily follow from biological traits. The *Mulieris Dignitatem*'s prescription of complementary roles is discriminatory without basis in sound reason, and gender roles must be overcome in order to liberate women.

In conclusion, the views expressed in the *Mulieris Dignitatem* are discriminatory towards women as they place an oppressive emphasis on their roles as mothers and attempts to impose this as a preordained, inescapable destiny, implicitly subjecting women to subordinate roles in society despite the Pope's claims of equal dignity.